



TokyoExpat

YOUR JAPAN RELOCATION EXPERTS

COMPLETE SETUP GUIDE

Your First Month in Tokyo

From residence card to bank account, SIM card to health insurance: your week-by-week setup guide for 2026.

WEEK 1

Legal Foundation

Residence Card + SIM card. Everything else depends on these two.

WEEK 2

Banking

Open a Japanese bank account. PayPay Bank or Sony Bank for foreigners.

WEEK 3

Social Protection

National Health Insurance and National Pension. Required by law.

WEEK 4

Utilities + ID

Electricity, gas, internet, and My Number Card application.

WEEK

1

Legal Foundation: Residence Card + SIM

These two items unlock everything else. Do them on Day 1.



DAY 1 — PRIORITY

Register at Ward Office (Shiyakusho)

Bring: passport, visa, accommodation address. You receive your Residence Card (在留カード). Without it: no bank, no lease, no NHI.



DAY 1-2

Get a Japanese SIM card

Sakura Mobile (airport pickup available) or IJmio. Requires passport + Residence Card. 3GB plan: ~1,200 JPY/month.



DAY 1

Get a Suica / Pasmo IC card

At any JR station. Load 3,000-5,000 JPY. Works on all trains, buses, taxis, convenience stores, vending machines.



WEEK 1

Withdraw cash at 7-Eleven ATM

7-Eleven ATMs accept all foreign cards (Visa, Mastercard). Japan is still largely cash-based. Keep 50,000 JPY on hand at all times.

Ward Office Hours

Mon-Fri 8:30-17:00. Some wards open 1st/3rd Saturday.

Sakura Mobile SIM

Data SIM from 1,100 JPY/mo. Voice plan: 2,200 JPY/mo. No guarantor needed.

Address format in Japan

Block/lot number system. Get it exact from landlord or booking.

Airport SIM counter

Terminal 1+2 at Narita, T2+3 at Haneda. Open 7:00-23:00.

WEEK

2

Banking: Open Your Japanese Account

Required for salary, rent payments, and tax. Most banks require 6+ months of residence. These do not.



BEST OPTION

PayPay Bank (online, English)

100% online setup. No waiting period. English UI. Free account. Fastest option for new arrivals. Requires My Number within 6 months.



ALTERNATIVE

Sony Bank

Excellent for international transfers. English app. Low ATM fees. Multi-currency account available. Apply online in 10 minutes.



TIP

Keep using Wise for transfers

Wise (formerly TransferWise) has the best EUR/USD to JPY rates. Use it alongside your Japanese account for international transfers.



WEEK 2-3

Set up PayPay digital wallet

Japan's most popular cashless payment. Link to Japanese bank account. Accepted at 90%+ of convenience stores, restaurants, taxis.

WEEK
3

Social Protection: Health Insurance + Pension

Both are mandatory by law for all residents in Japan. Do not skip this.



MANDATORY

National Health Insurance (NHI)

Apply at ward office. Cost: 5,000-25,000 JPY/month based on income. Covers 70% of medical costs. Bring: Residence Card + passport.



MANDATORY

National Pension (Kokumin Nenkin)

~16,980 JPY/month (2026). If low income, apply for full or partial exemption (menjo). Bring income documents to ward office.



AFTER NHI

Register with a local clinic

Find a "kakaritsuke-i" (family doctor) near your home. Most accept walk-ins. Google "clinic near me + your ward" — many have English staff.



BRIDGE INSURANCE

Keep SafetyWing until NHI activates

NHI takes 1-2 weeks to activate. Keep your travel/expat insurance active during this gap. SafetyWing Nomad Insurance: ~\$56/month.

Monthly Cost Summary — Social Protection	Low Income	Average	High Income
National Health Insurance	5,000 JPY	13,000 JPY	25,000 JPY
National Pension	0 JPY (exempt)	16,980 JPY	16,980 JPY
Total	~5,000	~30,000	~42,000

WEEK
4

Utilities + My Number Card Application

Set up electricity, gas, internet, and apply for your official Japanese ID card.



DAY 1 IN APARTMENT

Electricity (TEPCO)

Online signup at tepco.co.jp. English available. Activate same day. Flip the breaker in your apartment fuse box first.



BOOK EARLY

Gas (Tokyo Gas)

Technician visit required. Book at gas.or.jp. 1-2 week wait is common. You must be present. Take a half-day off work.



BOOK IMMEDIATELY

Internet (NURO Fiber / SoftBank)

Installation: 2-4 week wait. Use mobile data in the meantime. NURO: 2Gb fiber, ~4,950 JPY/month. Softbank Air: no construction, ~5,368 JPY.



APPLY WEEK 3-4

My Number Card (Kojin Bango Card)

Apply at ward office or online (mynaportal.digital.go.jp). Collection takes 3-6 weeks. Required for taxes, some banking, and government services.

ESSENTIAL APPS TO DOWNLOAD THIS MONTH

- Google Maps (EN transit)
- Google Translate (camera mode)
- PayPay
- LINE
- Suica app
- Hyperdia (trains)
- Tabelog (restaurants)
- My Number portal

BUDGET: WHAT YOUR FIRST MONTH WILL COST

Category	One-time Cost	Monthly Ongoing
Apartment deposit (2 months)	200,000-260,000 JPY	—
Agency fee	55,000-110,000 JPY	—
Rent (1K/1LDK, central Tokyo)	—	85,000-130,000 JPY
SIM card (voice + data)	0-3,000 JPY	2,200-3,300 JPY
National Health Insurance	—	~13,000 JPY
National Pension	—	16,980 JPY
Electricity + Gas	—	8,000-15,000 JPY
Internet (fiber)	Installation: 0-30,000 JPY	4,950-5,368 JPY
Groceries + Daily Life	—	40,000-70,000 JPY
Estimated First Month Total	400,000-500,000 JPY	~180,000 JPY

WEEK-BY-WEEK SUMMARY

Week 1 checklist

- ☐ Ward office: Residence Card
- ☐ SIM card (Sakura Mobile)
- ☐ Suica IC card
- ☐ Cash at 7-Eleven ATM
- ☐ Explore neighborhood

Week 2 checklist

- ☐ Open PayPay Bank (online)
- ☐ Set up PayPay wallet
- ☐ Continue apartment search
- ☐ Download essential apps
- ☐ Sign lease (if found)

Week 3 checklist

- ☐ National Health Insurance
- ☐ National Pension (or menjo)
- ☐ Find local clinic
- ☐ Book gas installation
- ☐ Order internet connection

Week 4 checklist

- ☐ Gas installation (be home)
- ☐ Electricity (TEPCO online)
- ☐ Apply for My Number Card
- ☐ Update bank with new address
- ☐ Register driving license (JAF)

USEFUL CONTACTS AND RESOURCES



Immigration Services Agency

immi-moj.go.jp — Residence card renewals, status changes, re-entry permits



My Number Portal

mynportal.digital.go.jp — My Number Card application and digital services



Foreign Resident Support Center

0570-013-904 — Multilingual support. Mon-Fri 9:00-17:00. English, French, Chinese, Korean.

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Relocation Checklist

90+ items from 6 months before to Day 1



Apartment Guide

Find housing in Tokyo as a foreigner



Consultation

1-on-1 session tailored to your situation

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